

KROOS



Creative

RODRI



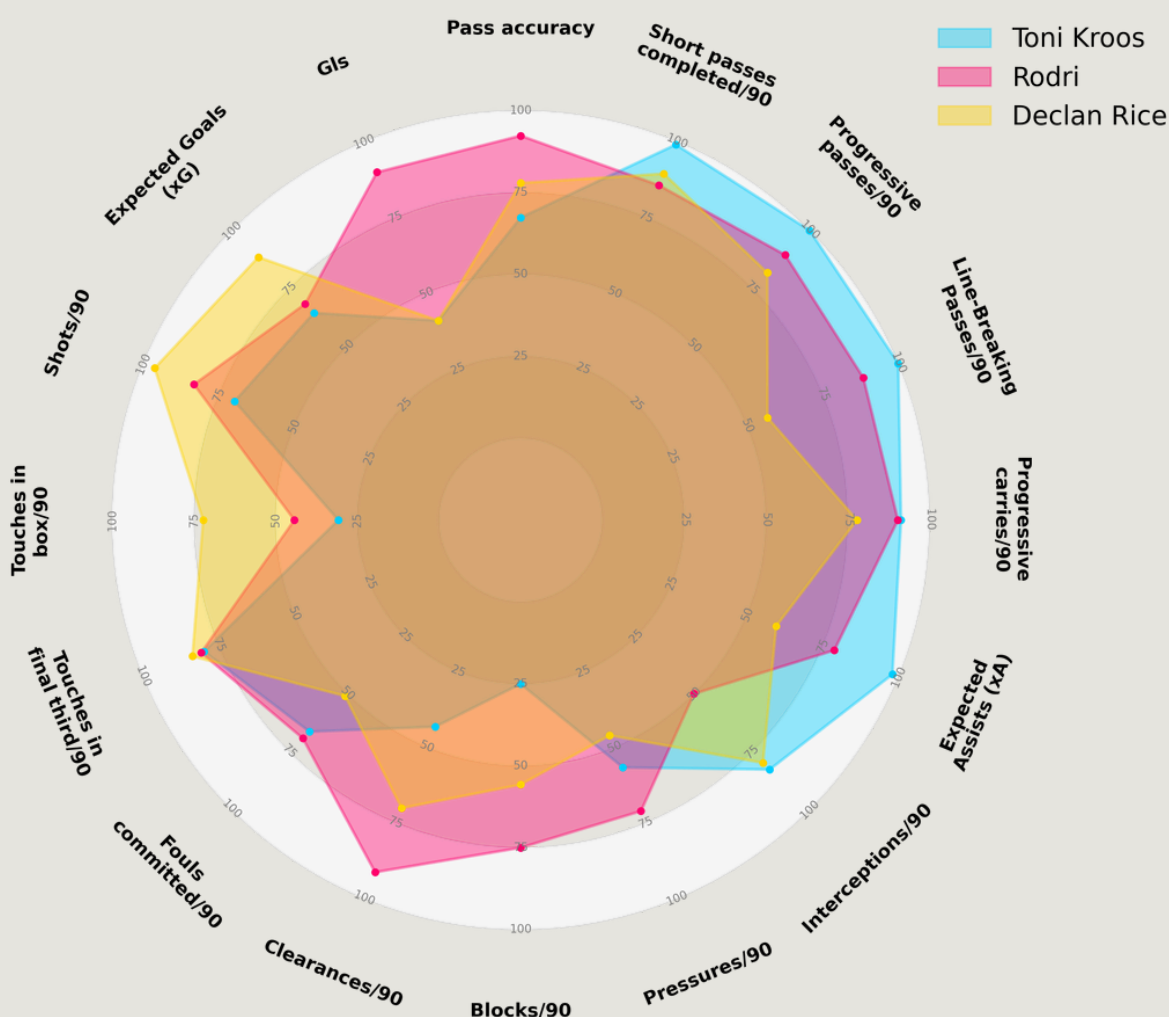
Holding midfielder

RICE



Box-to-box

In the last Euro, the midfield played a particularly important role. Many matches were decided by details in this area of the pitch. The question is: Who was the best midfielder of the tournament?



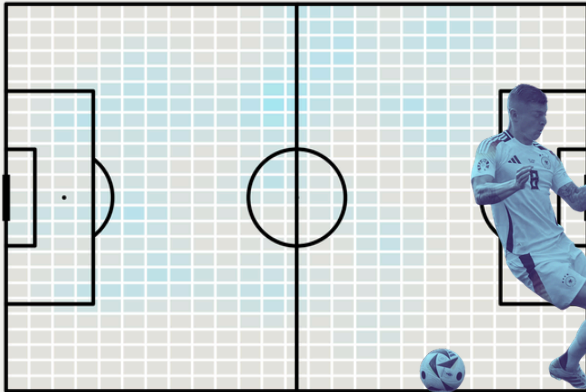
Data: EURO 2024 | Percentiles vs midfielders

Same position, different styles. Kroos stood out in build-up, progression, and offensive involvement. Rodri, the tournament winner, excelled in defensive actions, including pressing, while also securing possession for Spain (pass accuracy), which was crucial for their style. Rice, on the other hand, is halfway between Kroos and Rodri, adding more runs into the box to his game, with a greater ability to generate xG.

DEFENDING

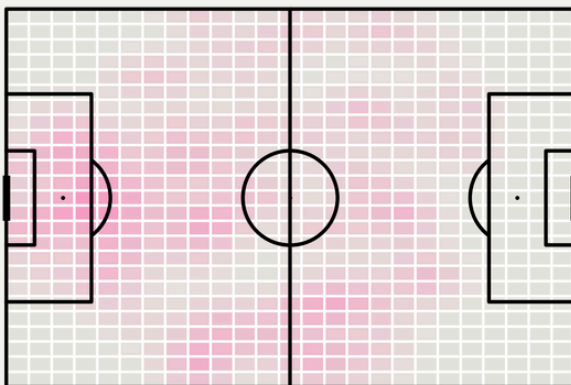
DEFENSIVE ACTIONS HEATMAP - EURO 2024

KROOS



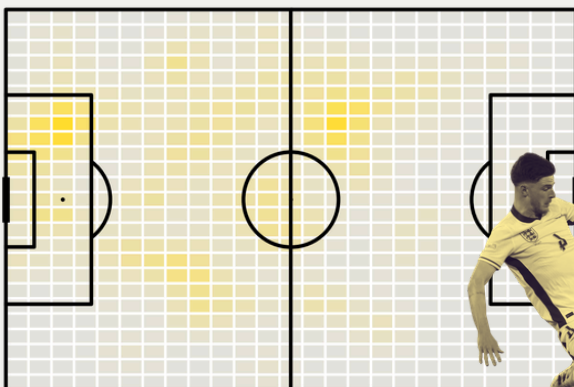
He is an effective ball-winner, ranking well in interceptions (82nd percentile) and fouls committed (66th percentile), many of which are tactical fouls to stop counterattacks — essential for his role. However, he contributes less when it comes to protecting his own penalty area, showing low outputs in clearances and blocks. The map highlights his low impact in this zone.

RODRI



Out of possession, he covers a large area, ranking high in defensive actions inside his own box — clearances (91.3rd percentile) and blocks (75th). With his leadership, he leads the team in pressing, with more pressures than 71% of midfielders, though still below Rice and Kroos. Breaks up play with fouls (69th percentile), but attempts fewer high interceptions.

RICE

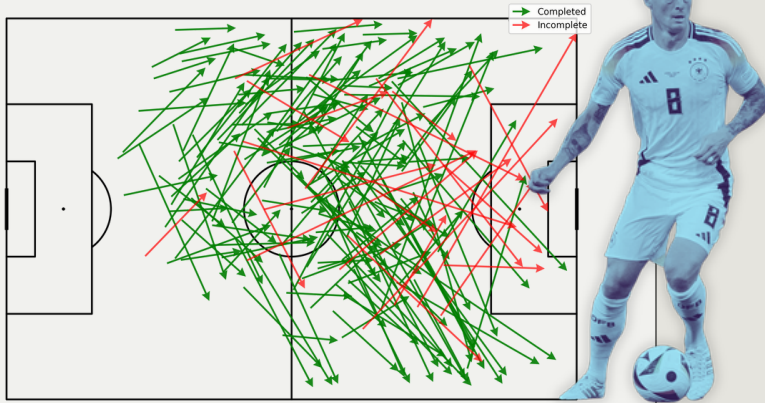


His physical presence and aerial ability provide solid defensive contribution in the box, with clearances (70th percentile) and blocks (55th) — good numbers, though below Rodri. With more freedom in England's setup, unlike Rodri or Kroos, he can play more aggressively, and his anticipation allows him to register a high volume of interceptions (80th percentile).

PROGRESSION

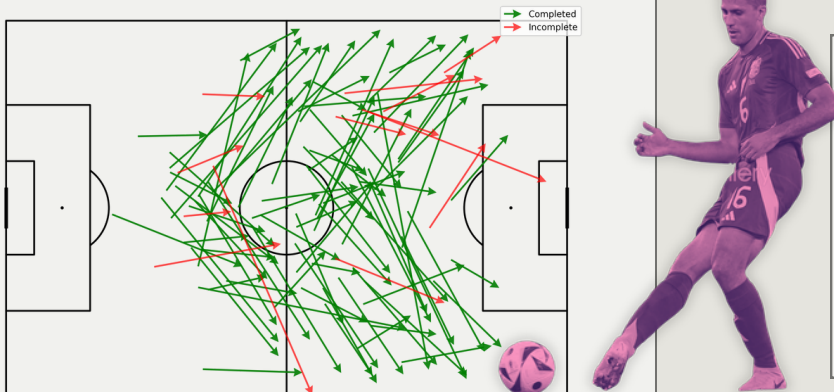
PROGRESSIVE PASSES MAP - EURO 2024

KROOS



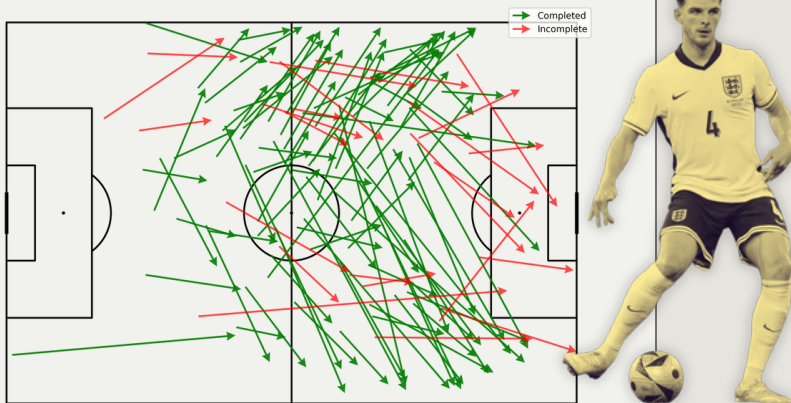
Progressive machine. The player with the highest progressive passing output in the tournament. This map highlights the German's massive involvement in possession. Beyond sheer volume, his distribution shows strong vertical progression, including many progressive passes into the final third and opposition box.

RODRI



Despite being the most defensive midfielder in the system, he still provides significant progression in possession. However, his progression is less vertical, taking fewer risks and offering limited passes into the penalty area.

RICE

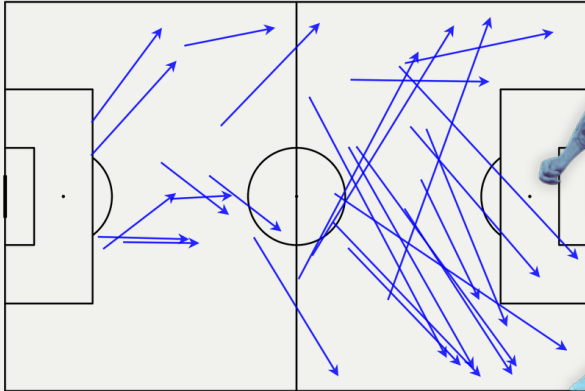


Due to his more offensive role and England's playing style, he contributes less overall progression than the other two players analyzed. We also see significant differences in the build-up phase (1st third), where he is far less involved. However, he provides progression in advanced areas through long switches of play and frequent attempts to play into the box.

UNLOCKING DEFENSES

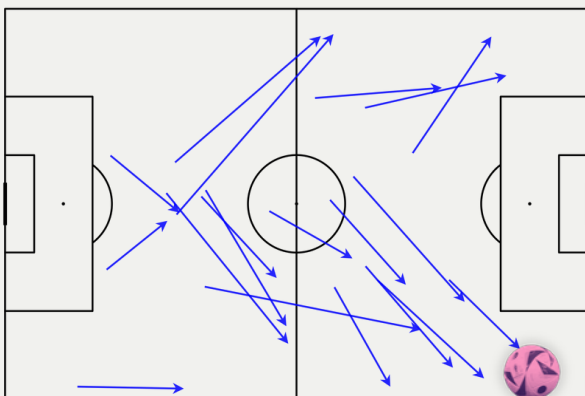
LINE-BREAKING PASSES MAP - EURO 2024

KROOS



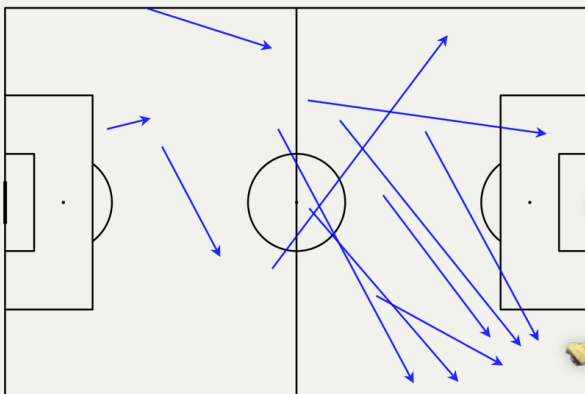
No midfielder has played more line-breaking passes than Kroos in the competition (4.9/90). We can clearly see a tendency to break lines down the right side. He often receives on his weaker foot to then dismantle the defensive structure on the opposite flank.

RODRI



Ranks in the 95th percentile for progressive passing among midfielders in the tournament (3.2/90). Still, his output falls short of Kroos — lower volume, shorter progression distance, and limited threat, with few passes reaching the penalty area.

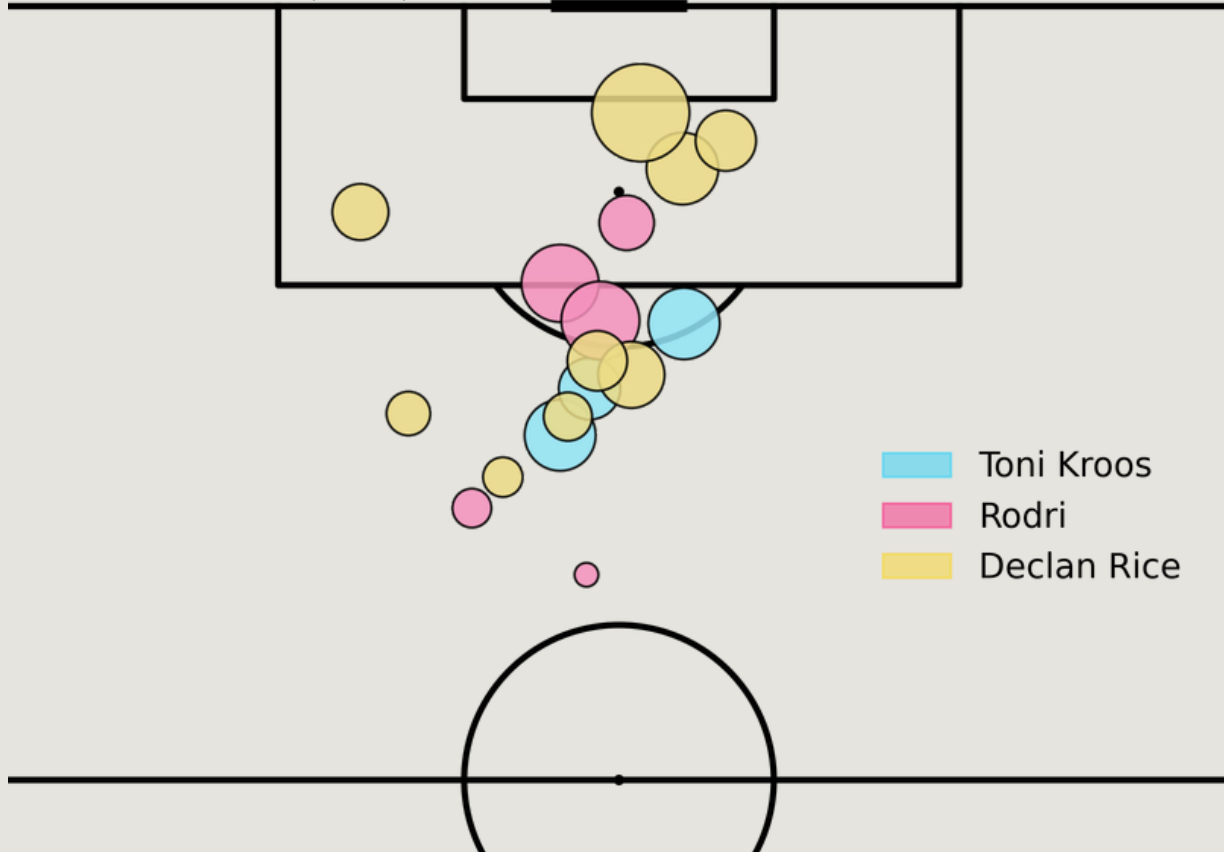
RICE



Solid output (76th percentile), though well below the other two players (1.4/90). Line-breaking passing isn't a standout attribute in his profile, but it's still present to some extent.

FINISHING & OFFENSIVE PARTICIPATION

SHOTS MAP - EURO 2024 (SIZE: xG)



Declan Rice ranked higher in goal threat, recording 0.4 xG — compared to Rodri and Kroos, both below 0.2. While all three attempted shots from outside the box, Rice provided greater penalty-box presence, consistently arriving in advanced positions. With reduced duties in first-phase build-up (Kroos) and defensive coverage (Rodri), he could advance into higher areas and exploit box spaces. England often overloaded the box, with crosses aimed at forwards or Rice making late runs.

This table highlights Rice's greater on-ball involvement in the final third, with an even larger disparity when measuring his touches inside the opposition penalty area relative to the other two midfielders.

PLAYER	T. FINAL 3RD/90	T. BOX/90
KROOS	79.8	0.73
RODRI	80.8	1.5
RICE	83.7	2.9

CONCLUSIONS

The analysis highlights how three midfielders, occupying a similar positional role, delivered very different contributions throughout EURO 2024.

- Kroos proved to be the reference point in build-up and progression, leading the tournament in line-breaking passes and ensuring verticality in possession.
- Rodri emerged as the most complete pivot, excelling in defensive actions and pressing while maintaining Spain's control through elite passing accuracy.
- Rice provided a more athletic and offensive profile, offering penalty-box presence and higher xG contribution, while still adding defensive value through interceptions and aerial ability.

These differences underline how midfield performance cannot be judged solely by raw numbers, but rather by how effectively each player's skill set fits into their team's tactical framework. Spain's triumph was built on Rodri's balance and control, while England maximized Rice's freedom to attack space, and Germany relied on Kroos's distribution to generate progression.

In conclusion, EURO 2024 confirmed that the modern midfielder must combine defensive reliability, progression, and offensive threat. Rodri, named Player of the Tournament, stood out as the most decisive overall, while Kroos and Rice demonstrated unique qualities that emphasize the variety of profiles required at the highest level.

